
Operational Policy

Policy title:	Password Policy		
Policy number:	ODHSOHA 090-014		
Original date:	10/04/2021	Last update:	05/01/2025
Approved:	Kris Kautz, Deputy Director OHA Seth Lyon, COO ODHS		

Purpose

Passwords or passphrases are the primary form of user authentication for granting access to Oregon Department of Human Services (ODHS) and the Oregon Health Authority (OHA) information systems. Compromised passwords or passphrases remain the top cause of data breaches. The purpose of this policy is to establish a standard for the creation of strong passwords or passphrases, the protection of those passwords or passphrases, and the frequency of change. Enterprise Information Services provides regulatory guidance for state agencies. This policy aligns ODHS and OHA with Statewide Information Technology (IT) Control Standards.

Description

This policy outlines the requirements for creating, storing, and using passwords or passphrases to enhance the security of user accounts and agency data.

Applicability

This policy applies to all ODHS and OHA staff including employees, volunteers, trainees, interns, as well as contractors and partners.

As keepers of the public trust, all agency employees have a responsibility to comply with state and agency policies, administrative rule, and state and federal law. The agency takes this responsibility seriously and failure to fulfill this responsibility is not treated lightly. Employees who fail to comply with state or agency policy, administrative rule, or state and federal law may face progressive discipline, up to and including dismissal from state service.

Policy

1. ODHS and OHA shall implement the identification and authentication related controls¹ mandated by the DAS 107-004-052 Cyber and Information Security Policy.
2. ODHS and OHA information system users shall use a combination of a unique username and password or passphrase to access all systems and applications. A passphrase is a sequence of words or other text and consists of a mixture uppercase and lowercase letters, numbers, and symbols.
3. Passwords or passphrases shall be constructed with these composition and complexity requirements:²
 - a. Minimum password or passphrase length of fifteen (15) characters. Long passwords and passphrases are allowed.
 - b. Minimum password or passphrase complexity to contain at least:
 - A. One (1) numeric: zero-9.
 - B. One (1) symbol such as, @, #, \$, %, ^, &, etc.
 - C. One (1) English uppercase letter: A-Z.
 - D. One (1) English lowercase letter: a-z.
 - c. No single dictionary words or common names unless used in passphrase context.
 - d. No portions of the associated account name or identifier such as User I.D. or login name may be used.
 - e. Enforce at least one (1) character change when new passwords or passphrases are selected for use.
4. Staff shall:
 - a. Use different passwords or passphrases for each network, system, and application-based account they access.
 - b. Keep passwords or passphrases confidential and shall not share passwords or passphrases to their accounts with anyone.
 - c. Store agency passwords or passphrases using secure and approved methods, such as agency approved password managers.
5. Temporary or default passwords or passphrases shall be changed at the first successful login.
6. If an account or password or passphrase is suspected to have been compromised, staff or the Office of Information Services (OIS) shall immediately:
 - a. Change the password or passphrase and reset Multifactor Authentication (MFA).
 - b. Notify the OIS Service Desk who then notifies ISPO.

¹ Statewide IT Control Standards, Identification and Authentication (IA)

² Statewide IT Control Standards IA-5(1)

7. Staff shall not use organization-provided identifiers such as email addresses, and authentication secrets such as passwords or passphrases, for creating accounts on social media, social networking sites, external sites, and applications.³
8. Password or passphrase consecutive timeouts have been set by the agency administrator. When the limit of consecutive failed log-ins has been reached, staff will need to contact the Service Desk to have their password or passphrase unlocked or reset.⁴
9. ODHS and OHA shall implement MFA for staff when local, network, or remote access to state assets are required for both privileged and non-privileged accounts.⁵ MFA requires a minimum of two of the following:
 - a. Something they know (personal identification number, password or passphrase).
 - b. Something they have (token, phone, card, key).
 - c. Something that identifies them individually (fingerprints, facial recognition, retinal patterns).
10. ODHS and OHA systems or applications shall provide a single sign-on capability where available.⁶
11. Password or passphrase lifetime restrictions and expirations for password or passphrase reset shall be one day minimum and 60 days maximum.⁷
12. Passwords or passphrases shall not be set to one of the last 24 previously used passwords.
13. ODHS and OHA system administrators shall:
 - a. Maintain or subscribe to a list of commonly used, expected, or compromised passwords or passphrases that are banned from use, and shall update the list quarterly.⁸
 - b. Verify, when users create or update passwords or passphrases, that the passwords or passphrases are not found on the list of commonly used, expected, or compromised passwords or passphrases.⁹
14. When a password or passphrase is issued or changed, or communicated for other reasons, the password or passphrase:
 - a. Shall be sent securely by email or other electronic communication.
 - b. Shall not be sent with other identifying information.
15. Agency information systems and applications shall not display passwords or passphrases in plain text and shall only transmit encrypted passwords or passphrases.

³ Statewide IT Control Standards PL-4(1)

⁴ Statewide IT Control Standards AC-7(a)(b)

⁵ Statewide IT Control Standards IA-2(6)

⁶ National Institute for Standards and Technology (NIST) Special Publication 800-53 Revision 5 IA-2(10)

⁷ Statewide IT Control Standards IA-5(1)(j)

⁸ Statewide IT Control Standards IA-5(1)(a)

⁹ Statewide IT Control Standards IA-5(1)(b)

16. The use of administrator account passwords or passphrases shall follow ODHSOHA 090-013 Administrative Privileges Policy.

References

[45 CFR 160 General Administrative Requirements](#)

[45 CFR 164 Security and Privacy](#)

[Center for Internet Security Controls](#)

[Center for Internet Security Password Policy Guide](#)

[Center for Internet Security MS-ISAC Security Primer-Securing Login Credentials](#)

[Criminal Justice Information Services \(CJIS\) Security Policy](#)

[IRS Publication 1075, Tax Information Security Guidelines for Federal, State and Local Agencies](#)

[Acceptable Risk Controls for Affordable Care Act for Medicaid Partner Exchanges](#)

[National Institute of Standards and Technology \(NIST\) Special Publications \(SP\) 800-53 Rev. 5](#)

[Statewide Information Technology \(IT\) Control Standards](#)

[ODHS and OHA Information Security Incident Response Plan](#)

[Statewide Information Security Program Plan](#)

Related policies

[DAS 107-004-052 Cyber and Information Security Policy](#)

[DAS 107-004-110 Acceptable Use of State Information Assets Policy](#)

[ODHSOHA 090-003 Access Control Policy](#)

[ODHSOHA 090-009 Administrative, Technical and Physical Safeguards of Information Policy](#)

[ODHSOHA 090-013 Administrative Privileges Policy](#)

This policy shall be reviewed at least once every year to ensure relevance.

Contact

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Policy history

Version 1 Established 10/04/2021

Version 2 Revised 05/01/2025

Keywords

Access, authentication, multi-factor, rights, secure

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